

Throughout most of recorded history, however, circumcision has been a ritual, establishing a visible sign of a covenant with God. In other societies, largely in Africa and Australia, it was a rite of passage, performed at puberty or prior to marriage."

Circumcision gained popularity in Western medicine during the 18th century when doctors blamed masturbation for a variety of problems, including epilepsy, stammering, acne, blindness, alcoholism, tuberculosis, rheumatism and 'masturbatory insanity'. Doctors believed that circumcision would stop boys from masturbating and thus, cure these ailments.

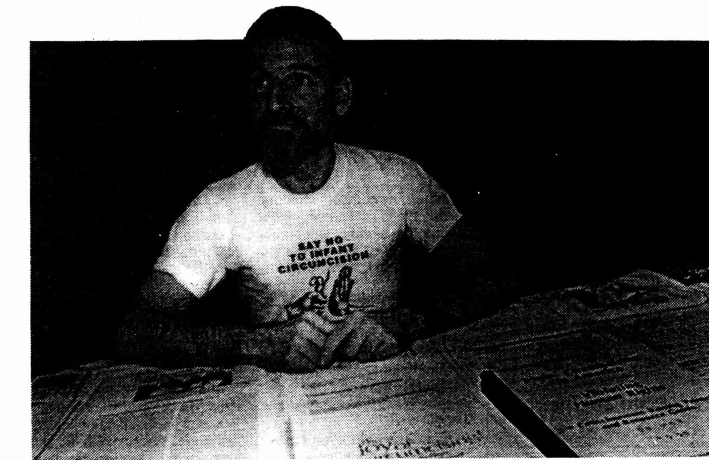
Briggs writes that by the late 1800s, the idea that masturbation could cause insanity and disease was losing hold. American doctors then changed their minds, claiming it was the foreskin itself that caused problems.

As it became obvious that circumcision wasn't preventing any of the ills its proponents promised to cure, "the American medical community simply adopted other rationales," Briggs writes. "Beginning in the 1930s, some physicians began insisting that circumcision would prevent cancer of the penis and the prostate and ... cancer of the cervix." The same justifications are used today.

"Circumcision is based on a strong irrational bias," Milos says. "Advocates use one irrationality after another to perpetuate a surgery that most of the world scorns."

#### Like removing eyelids

At an educational forum held February 7, NO HARM presented speakers involved in the fight against routine circumcision.



Tim Hammond of the National Organization to Halt the Abuse and Routine Mutilation of Males passes out information on circumcision.

(Photo: Rick Gerharter)

Hammond disputed claims that circumcision is a minor operation that makes little difference to a man's body. According to the book *The Human Connection*, by Ashley Montagu and Floyd Matson, a piece of skin the size of a quarter contains more than 3 million cells, 12 feet of nerves and 50 nerve endings.

Hammond explains that an adult's foreskin — measured from outside the base of the glans, around the tip and back inside where the foreskin folds around the glans — is about equal in size to a 3x5 index card.

"That's 36 percent of a man's penile shaft skin and an area that would easily fit 15 quarters," Hammond says. "In fact, circumcision robs men of 240 feet of nerves and 1,000 nerve endings."

Jim Bigelow, a psychologist, clergyman and author of *The Joy of Uncircumcising*, points out that the foreskin is a body part whose specific function is to protect the head of the penis.

"Removing the foreskin is more like removing an eyelid than removing an unnecessary flap of skin," Bigelow says. "The foreskin has a definite function."

#### Injuries documented

In his work with NO HARM, Hammond collects testimony from men who have been harmed by botched circumcisions or who are unhappy with the results of their "successful" circumcisions.

Hammond last year attempted to meet with Richard Corlin, president of the California Medical Association, to discuss the damage men have

reported. Corlin declined to meet with him.

Attorney Charles Bonner of Sausalito disputes whether there is any such thing as a "successful" circumcision. Bonner says he receives four or five calls per month regarding medical problems from circumcisions. He goes to trial in March on a case in which a boy's dorsal artery was cut during the operation.

"Circumcision itself is an injury," Bonner says. "They're doing this to boys all over the country and it has got to stop. If they were doing it to whales people wouldn't tolerate it. They are harming boys, they are literally causing serious injuries."

San Francisco resident Ed Van Egri lived with the scar tissue from his botched circumcision for 39 years until he

discovered he could do something about it. Van Egri describes "a big hunk of scar tissue about the size of a postage stamp" that connected the head of his penis to the shaft, causing his penis to bend during erections.

"It took a lot of guts to call somebody and say, 'My prick is a mess. Can you fix it up for me,'" Van Egri says. "A plastic surgeon remedied the problem although I still ended up with a circumcised penis."

"They went ahead and chopped something off of me which was not diseased without my permission," Van Egri says. "Just like if they had cut off my ears because my parents didn't want to clean them. It has been done so routinely for such a long time, it as become an acceptable thing."

#### Not supported by law

"It's a medical procedure done through custom and myth and no law says it can be done," attorney Bonner says. "Case law says that parents may authorize any necessary surgery for their children, but this is an unnecessary surgery — the medical community will agree that it is unnecessary surgery. No case law says parents can authorize a procedure that has no medical benefit. Technically, circumcisions are as illegal as robbing the bank. It happens to continue under custom."

Hammond hopes to change that. Along with its ongoing lobbying of doctors and medical associations, NO HARM is calling on Hillary Rodham Clinton to consider the issue as she reforms health care.

When England adopted socialized medicine in 1948, circumcision was categorized as a cosmetic surgery not covered by insurance. The British cir-

cumcision rate has fallen to a level of about 1 percent today.

Hammond says that a new U.S. health plan excluding circumcision from its package of covered benefits could have a similar result in this country, where about 60 percent of male infants are now circumcised each year.

The United States is alone in its high circumcision rate, according to the book *Say No to Circumcision* by physician Thomas Ritter. He writes that most countries in Europe, Asia, Central America, and South America do not practice circumcision to any great degree.

Impeding a change in U.S. policy, circumcision critics agree, is the fact that circumcision is endorsed by circumcised men who don't see it as a problem.

"If men have been cut, they've been wounded and they cannot recognize that condition as being some kind of injury in another person," Bonner says. "This fight is just beginning. Many of us are committed to it. Already we've seen change; the circumcision rate on the West Coast is down from 90 percent to 43 percent in the last three years because of education by organizations like NOCIRC and NOHARM." ▼

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